behind, and they acted both as aggregators of the opium grown in western India as well as engaged in direct trade, mainly through Mumbai. The Malwa opium was in direct competition with the more tightly controlled export trade through Kolkata. At first the British tried to control the Malwa trade, but since the princely states of the Scindias and others in Rajasthan were not directly under their jurisdiction, and neither were the Portuguese ports of Daman and Diu, such efforts ended in failure. The British recognized this by permitting the trade but benefiting through a small tax imposed on the export. The emergence of Mumbai as India's major commercial hub and port is directly related to its role in the opium trade. Amar Farooqi, a historian, who has studied this subject in detail, has concluded,

> . . . the destiny of Bombay as a great commercial centre was born of its becoming an accomplice in drugging of countless Chinese with opium. A venture in which the Indian business class showed great zeal. [3]

The opium trade and its enrichment of a new class of Indian merchants also spawned a growing interest in Chinese decorative arts and designs. Chinese motifs began to find their way into Indian fashion, and Parsi women wore sarees embroidered with Chinese symbols such as the phoenix and the dragon. Jewellery crafted from Chinese jade became popular in Indian urban centres, as did fine Chinese porcelain. The spread of British-style tea drinking with milk and sugar among the newly rich merchant class in India led to the acquisition of fine Chinese porcelain in which to prepare and drink the tea.

The heavy demand for tea in Britain also led to efforts to grow tea in India itself, and soon large-scale tea plantations spread across northern Bengal, Assam and in the foothills of Kangra in present-day Himachal Pradesh. The use of sugar with tea also stimulated the growing of sugar in the far-flung British colonies – in India itself, and in the Caribbean and South Africa. The spread of sugar plantations was associated with the infamous slave trade, and later with the use of indentured labour from India in British colonies, which expanded significantly after the abolition of slavery throughout the British empire in 1863.